Salutations and Valedictions

A salutation is a greeting. It is a formal way of saying hello and is used to start a message.
To end the message we use a valediction, which a formal way to say goodbye.

Here are some salutations you can use to start your message



Dear Sir or Madam	To a company
Dear Sir	To a man if you do not know his name
Dear Madam	To a woman if you do not know her name
Dear Mr Smith	To a married or unmarried man
Dear Ms Smith	To a married or unmarried woman
Dear Mrs Smith	To a married woman
Dear Miss Smith	To an unmarried woman
Dear Jay Smith	To someone whose gender you do not know
Dear John	To a friend or someone you know well

Unless you are certain that a woman prefers Miss or Mrs, you should use the title Ms
If you do not know the person's name or gender you can also use

To whom it may concern
Although this can appear to be quite impersonal.
Regarding punctuation after the salutation, in the USA and Canada it is common practice to add a colon
Dear Sir:
In areas where British English is more commonly used, a comma might be used
Dear Sir,
However, it is equally acceptable to use no punctuation at all
Dear Sir
To end the message use a valediction, which a formal way to say goodbye.

The way you end the message depends on how you open it:

Dear Sir or Madam	Yours faithfully
Dear Mr Smith	Yours sincerely
Dear John	Best wishes

Note that you must write **Yours faithfully** or **Yours sincerely** with an **s** on the end.
***Your sincerely* or *Your faithfully* without an s is not correct.**
This is a common mistake made by second language learners who are Thai.